



William Robert Williamson

1896 - 1915

Civilian Research

Field Name	Field Data	Source of data
Casualty Name	W Williamson William Robert Williamson – found obituary with mention of school	School plaque and 1919 roll of honour Harrow Observer (see below)
Date of Birth	c1896 Baptised 1/3/1896, Northwood Parish Church. Difficult to read but looks like he was born in January 1896	Baptism register (Ancestry)
Date of Death (from Spreadsheet)	25/5/1915 but newspaper report says 9/6/1915	CWGC and Harrow Observer (see below)
Age at death (from Spreadsheet)	19	
Marital Status		
Occupation prior to Call up	L&NW Railway	Obituary in Harrow Observer (see below)

	On the 1911 census he is listed as working as a Railway Clerk aged 15	1911 census
Parents	Son of William and Agnes Williamson, of 83 Hallowell Rd, Northwood, Middx	CWGC and Harrow Observer (see below)
Listed Address(s)	As above	
Parents /Fathers occupation	Railway Clerk in 1911	1911 census
Brothers and Sisters	Muriel Agnes Williamson, Marjorie Jeanne Lothead Williamson (all younger than him). Obituary in Harrow Observer says he was the only son	
Obituary	See clips below from Harrow Observers	
Additional sources of data		
War Memorials:	John Lyon School, plaque	https://memorials.iwm.org.uk/name/341009
	John Lyon School, sundial	https://memorials.iwm.org.uk/memorial/11318
	Northwood War Memorial	https://memorials.iwm.org.uk/memorial/2176
	L&NW Railway WW1 Roll of Honour - I assume he's on this	https://www.warmemorialsonline.org.uk/memorial/172589

Military Research

JLS WWI RoH	WILLIAMSON W.R.
CWGC Reference	https://www.cwgc.org/find-war-dead/casualty/3055333/williamson,-william-robert/
Age	19
DoD	25-May-15
Rank	AB
Regiment	Royal Navy Volunteer Reserve (RNVR) Drake Bn RN Div
Organisations must have served or have members who served in the Ypres Salient or the Somme in World War One.	HELLES MEMORIAL
Location	Turkey
Military details	Son of William and Agnes Williamson, of 83, Hallowell Rd., Northwood, Middx. Able Seaman William Robert Williamson (Service Number: London 8/3138) was killed in action on May 25, 1915, during the Gallipoli Campaign. He was 26 years old. He served with the Drake Battalion of the Royal Naval Division (RND). This unique division was formed by the Royal Navy from surplus naval reservists to fight on land alongside the British Army. He died at the Cape Helles sector of the Gallipoli Peninsula in modern-day Turkey. The Drake Battalion landed at Gallipoli in late April 1915 and was quickly thrust into brutal, close-quarters trench warfare against defending Ottoman forces. Throughout May 1915, the battalion was holding highly volatile, primitive trench lines at Helles, facing constant artillery bombardments, sniper fire, and localized counter-attacks. Able Seaman Williamson was killed during these daily, attrition-heavy trench combat operations. Memorialization Because he fell during the chaotic early months of the campaign and his remains could not be recovered or individually identified, he has no known grave. He is officially commemorated on the Helles Memorial in Turkey on Panels 8 to 15.

Story of Sacrifice

William Robert Williamson (1896–1915)

William Robert Williamson was a Northwood Lyonian and railway clerk who joined the Royal Naval Division shortly before the outbreak of the First World War. He served at Antwerp and in the Dardanelles campaign before being killed in action at Cape Helles in May 1915.

Civilian Life

William Robert Williamson was born in Northwood in 1896 and was the only son of William and Agnes Williamson of Hallowell Road, Northwood. He was educated first at Northwood Church School, then at the Lower School of John Lyon, and finally under Mr E. A. Cave at Harrow. After completing his education, he joined the staff of the London and North Western Railway, where he worked as a railway clerk.

Military Life

Before the outbreak of war, Williamson joined the Naval Division in April 1914 and, when war was declared, was called up for service with the Royal Naval Volunteer Reserve. He trained at Lambeth and Deal before being sent with the Naval Division. This unique division was formed by the Royal Navy from surplus naval reservists to fight on land alongside the British Army. In the first months of the war, the Belgian Army held out in Antwerp to disrupt the German Army's logistics and communication to the front in France. Williamson deployed to Antwerp when British troops including units from the Naval Division were sent to assist. He was among units that safely evacuated before Antwerp fell. (Others escaped to neutral Netherlands and remained interned until the end of the war.)

Further training followed at the Crystal Palace and in Berwickshire, after which he sailed for Egypt in March 1915, spending several weeks at Port Said and Alexandria before being sent to the Dardanelles. The Drake Battalion of the Naval Division landed at Gallipoli in late April 1915 and was quickly thrust into brutal, close-quarters trench warfare against defending Ottoman forces. Throughout May 1915, the battalion was holding highly volatile, primitive trench lines at Helles, facing constant artillery bombardments, sniper fire, and localized counter-attacks. Able Seaman Williamson was killed during these daily, attrition-heavy trench combat operations at Cape Helles on 25 May 1915, aged 19. A later newspaper report stated that an officer had written that his body was found with a bullet wound through the heart and that death must have been instantaneous. He was buried by moonlight with three other men.

As his grave was subsequently lost, Williamson is commemorated on the Helles Memorial in Turkey. His name was also recorded on the John Lyon School memorials and the Northwood War Memorial.

Photo



Williamson Photo AI



Williamson Photo Original

Notes and Clippings

Obituary Harrow Observer 25/6/1915		
Obituary Harrow Observer 25/6/1915		A.B. SEAMAN WILLIAMSON. Not only Harrow residents, but those in the neighbouring districts, too, will learn with the deepest regret of the death of A.B. Seaman William Robert Williamson, of the Drake Battalion of the Royal Naval Volunteer Reserve, who was killed in action at the Dardanelles on June 9 (sic: CWGC Says 25th May). The only son of Mr. and Mrs. W. Williamson, of Eildon, Hollowell-road, Northwood, the deceased, in his schooldays, was first under Mr. T. H. Fendick, at the Northwood Church School, and later he became attached to the Lower School of John Lyon, and finally finished his education under Mr. E. A. Cave, at Harrow. He later became a member of the L. and N.W.R. staff, and in April, before war was declared, he joined the Naval Division. When war was declared, he was immediately called upon, and was for some time stationed at Lambeth, and later at Deal, for training. From there he was sent to Antwerp with the Naval Division, and came through that engagement safely. After that trying experience he was at the Crystal Palace, from whence he went into Berwickshire for further training, and at the beginning of March he sailed for Egypt and was at Port Said and Alexandra for several weeks before going to the Dardanelles. He was nineteen years of age.



Reproduced from [“The Lyonian.”]
A.B. SEAMAN W. R. WILLIAMSON,
of the Drake Battalion of the R.N.V.R., who was
killed in action at the Dardanelles on June 9.

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SEAMAN W. R. WILLIAMSON.

The "London and North-Western Rly. Gazette" gives a few further particulars relating to the death of Seaman W. R. Williamson, the Old Lyonian, of Northwood, who, as recorded in the OBSERVER, was killed in action. He was the only son of Mr. W. Williamson, of the Expenditure Department, Euston, and took part in the expedition to Antwerp, with the Drake Battalion, R.N.V.R., getting away safely from there to be sent to the Dardanelles, where he met his death. A letter received from one of the officers states that the body was found with a bullet wound through the heart, and death must have been instantaneous. He feelingly refers to the regard all of them had for their late comrade, and to the burial which took place by moonlight, three others being buried in the same grave.

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Harrow Observer 10/9/1915

Harrow Observer 10/9/1915

is not thrust down their throats, for the work is mostly to counteract the wet canteens."

THE ROLL OF HONOUR.—In the current issue of the Holy Trinity Church Parish Magazine appears the following : " To the credit of Northwood, be it said, we have sent a good supply of men into the fighting Forces of our country, and not many eligible men are left in our parish. But we are paying our toll. Some of those who went out from us in response to our King's call have given their lives and will not return to us. We honour their memories, and we deeply sympathise with their mourning relatives. Captain Blathwayt and Captain Pickersgill Cuncliffe worshipped with us when staying in the parish. Seamen William Williamson and Ronald King, of the Royal Navy, were members of families numbered among the congregation ; Lieut. G. G. Glyn was a parishioner and member of a family closely connected with the Church ; and Lieut. James C. Taylor, although not a parishioner, is the first of our Church workers to fall. He had been a Sunday School teacher, and for more than ten years a constant member of the choir. When he joined the Army he still kept up his active Christian work, and by example and influence was of great assistance to his men."

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Williamson, W

William Williamson was in the Royal Naval Volunteer reserve and was killed in action at the Dardanelles.